



FIREFIGHTING, 1941

Shostakovich is pictured with a hose on the roof of the Leningrad Conservatoire in his role as a firefighter in the first year of the siege of Leningrad (1941–1944) during World War II.

IN CONTEXT

The Siege of Leningrad

In April 1941, Hitler began the offensive against Leningrad in conjunction with the Finnish attack on the region from the north. Evacuation of the population began in June that year, but by September all roads out of the city were blocked, and the long siege began. Rather than occupy the city, Hitler announced that “Leningrad must die of starvation,” amid continual bombardment. Hundreds of thousands of civilians died of cold and starvation, leading some to classify the campaign as genocidal. Lasting 872 days, the siege was one of the longest in history, and was finally lifted in January 1944.